

Cardpick: How and Why

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Cardpick answers one question for a specific flight: which card to pay with, on which platform, and what I will actually save. Everything below follows from treating that as a decision, not a list.

How I framed the problem

The offer decides everything. The card, the platform and often the airline are outputs of the offer, not inputs. So the user gives two things, their cards and their route, and the product works backwards from every offer's fine print to one answer.

- **A decision, not a catalogue.** Five cards across four platforms is 20 combinations. Showing 12 offers only moves the comparison work onto the user.
- **A discovery layer.** Cardpick never books. It hands the user to the OTA with the context they need to finish there.
- **Priced on the real fare.** A banner says "12% off up to ₹1,200". The useful number is what that becomes on this fare, on this airline, today.

What "best offer" means

I rank by the lowest price the user is likely to actually pay, not by the biggest discount. Saving the most and being able to use the offer point in different directions, so I made that trade-off visible instead of hiding it in a score.

- **Certainty-weighted.** Anything I can't verify lowers confidence: a monthly usage cap, a first-booking-only rule, cashback paid later, an EMI-only condition. Each recommendation carries a label: Will apply, Likely to apply or Depends on you.
- **Net price beats percentage.** On Delhi to Mumbai, HDFC on MakeMyTrip excludes Akasa, the cheapest airline. Booked on IndiGo it still ends up ₹516 below the cheapest fare without any offer, so it wins.
- **The bigger saving gets its own slot.** Axis on Cleartrip saves ₹932, but only on Tuesday bookings. It appears as "Save more if you can wait", with the catch stated, never as the headline.
- **"Not worth it" is a real state.** An offer that saves ₹800 on Air India but still costs more than the cheapest fare is flagged, not recommended.

Conditions, designed honestly

Every condition is checked against the flight and shown with its status. Nothing that could block the user is buried in terms and conditions.

- **Four states, one vocabulary.** Confirmed, Can't verify, Your call (for example, EMI only) and Blocks it.
- **Calm by default.** Confirmed items collapse into one line ("4 of 5 conditions met"). Only what needs the user gets its own row, phrased as a consequence: "If you've used it this month, it won't apply."
- **Advertised versus actual.** One quiet line, and only when they differ: "Advertised 12%, but the ₹1,800 cap means you get 9.2%."
- **Full terms one tap away.** The offer detail lists every condition, so honesty doesn't cost clarity on the main screen.

When nothing applies

"Nothing applies" is a valid answer, so I designed it as one: a clear headline, then a next step. On Bengaluru to Goa the fares sit below every minimum spend, and the screen says so plainly.

- **Stop the hunt.** "None of your cards has an offer for this flight. We checked all 10."
- **What I'd do instead.** Book the cheapest fare direct with the airline, plus an alert if an offer appears.
- **Near misses that teach.** Each blocked offer gives its reason and how to unlock it: "Needs ₹5,000+. Works if you book for 2." Minimum spends count the whole booking, which most people don't know.

The input, without a five-minute form

Route first, then cards, and cards only once. Returning users go straight from route to answer.

- **Route as taps.** Two city pickers, a date strip that shows the cheapest fare per day, and a travellers stepper with the note "Offer minimums count the whole booking."
- **Cards by product, never by number.** Users tap the cards they own as visuals in a grid. Each one flies into a wallet dock. No card number, CVV or OTP, and the screen says so.
- **Show the work.** A short matching screen draws card-to-platform lines with a progress bar, so the result feels earned rather than random.

Visual and interaction choices

The look is premium fintech: quiet and confident. Money is the loudest thing on the screen.

- **One system.** A dark canvas, a serif for headlines and figures, Inter for everything else, copper only for labels and links, and gold reserved for the saving.
- **The card is the hero object.** Realistic cards (chip, network mark, masked number) in a stacked wallet that shows each card's status for this flight, plus a 3D tilt on the recommendation.
- **Motion with a job.** A card joining the wallet, lines connecting during matching, and the card flying into the platform's logo at handoff. Each one explains what just happened.
- **The answer as the headline.** "Pay with HDFC Regalia on MakeMyTrip." Saving and price sit in the card below, each fact said once.
- **Accessible in both themes.** Light and dark modes share tokens, all text meets WCAG AA, and reduced motion is respected.

Positions I took that weren't asked for

- **No card upsell.** I won't suggest a new card to save a few hundred rupees on one flight. Trust is the product.
- **Context survives the handoff.** A "Remember to pay with" screen and "Copy offer details" carry the card, code, minimum and what to watch out for into the OTA.
- **Recovery, not errors.** If an offer ends while the user is away, the old card collapses and the next best appears.
- **Earned inspiration.** A "Bali for two" idea, exclusive with 30 Sundays, appears only after the user has their answer. It turns card benefits into a trip, which is the business loop.

What I'd test next

1. Do people trust "Likely to apply" enough to act, or do they want the monthly-limit check themselves?
2. Does "Save more if you can wait" change booking behaviour or just add doubt?
3. Real fares and offer feeds: the prototype uses sample data and assumes the same fare on every platform.